stabilising influence of India." This, and not military alliances, should be the means used to counter China—alliances would only lead to additional conflict with the Soviet Union and allow China to portray itself as the "champion of Asian nationalism." Haksar acknowledged that this might prove a hard sell to the US because Washington now doubted "India's stabilising capacity" and the country's "viability."[78]

When Nixon traveled to India, Gandhi was preoccupied with domestic political struggles that would eventually lead to the split of the Congress Party. The visit, however, went relatively well. Nixon left Gandhi worried about the outcome in Vietnam, but impressed with the president's genuine interest in finding an honorable settlement. She told Kosygin that the American president was finding a way to "register their presence in the Pacific and in South and South-East Asia," but not through military alliances.[79]

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Nixon might have reassured Gandhi, but China did not. By fall 1969, Indian officials indicated to their American counterparts that they did not perceive many signs that China was "softening" its attitude—though they did believe that "Chinese respect for power" could lead Beijing to seek increased communication with Washington and Moscow.[80] In spring 1970, an Indian request to the Chinese foreign office to meet in Beijing to discuss Cambodia "met with a rebuff" even though it was a subject of Chinese interest.[81]

There was particular concern about Beijing's "extremely hostile, false and tendentious propaganda against our country."[82] Through the first few months of 1970, accusations continued to flow from China, especially about India's relationship with the US. Chinese statements termed India a "lackey of US imperialism and Soviet revisionism in international affairs." They accused India of "coordinat[ing] with [the] US in carrying out the so called US 'new Asian policy' of using Asians to fight Asians" in return for "more rewards." Indian diplomats saw Chinese accusations that India was "forcibly occupying Kashmir" as a new addition to its hostile statements.[83] And allegations about India and Tibet left Indian officials concerned about the "implied threat" that China would retaliate by interfering in more internal Indian affairs.[84]